MIDNIGHT WEBS · FREE RESOURCE

Website Launch Security Checklist

Use this checklist before you point a new website at your domain. It covers the access, HTTPS, backup and launch basics that prevent the most common problems.

UPDATED NOVEMBER 2026 · 12 MIN READ · MIDNIGHTWEBS.COM

1. Accounts and access

Most website compromises start with weak or reused credentials, not sophisticated attacks. Fix the basics before launch.

- [ ] Use a unique password for every admin account; store them in a password manager.
- [ ] Turn on two-factor authentication for hosting, the domain registrar, the CMS/admin panel and business email.
- [ ] Remove old admin accounts and anyone who no longer needs access.
- [ ] Give each person their own account; never share logins.
- [ ] Use the smallest permission level that still lets each person do their job.
- [ ] Keep a secure record of who owns each account and how to recover it.

2. Domain, DNS and HTTPS

Your domain and DNS control trust. A misconfigured record can redirect visitors or let attackers send email as your brand.

- [ ] Enable registrar lock and two-factor authentication on the domain account.
- [ ] Confirm the SSL certificate is valid, covers the correct domain and renews automatically.
- [ ] Redirect HTTP to HTTPS and test every page.
- [ ] Add SPF, DKIM and DMARC records for business email.
- [ ] Remove unused DNS records and subdomains.
- [ ] Enable HSTS only after HTTPS works on every subdomain.

3. Platform and software

Every old plugin is another way in. Keep the platform current and remove what you do not use.

- [ ] Update the CMS, plugins, themes and server packages before launch.
- [ ] Delete plugins, themes and extensions you do not use.

- [ ] Remove sample content, demo users and default admin usernames.
- [ ] Disable directory listing and file editing in the admin panel where possible.
- [ ] Set secure file permissions and keep secrets out of public files.
- [ ] Use a web application firewall or security rules if your host provides them.

4. Forms, payments and data

Forms and checkout are the parts of the site that accept untrusted input. Treat every field as hostile until it has been validated.

- [ ] Add CAPTCHA or rate limiting to public forms.
- [ ] Validate and sanitize every input on the server, not only in the browser.
- [ ] Use CSRF protection for logged-in actions.
- [ ] Collect only the data you actually need, and explain why you collect it.
- [ ] Store form submissions in a protected system, not in plain email if they contain sensitive data.
- [ ] Use hosted payment fields so card data never touches your server.

5. Backups and recovery

A backup you have never restored is only a hope. Test recovery before you need it.

- [ ] Turn on automatic daily backups.
- [ ] Keep at least one backup outside the hosting account.
- [ ] Encrypt backups that contain personal data.
- [ ] Test a restore before launch, not during an incident.
- [ ] Write down who can restore, where backups live and how long recovery takes.

6. Monitoring and response

You cannot fix what you cannot see. Make sure someone is watching the important signals.

- [ ] Enable uptime, malware and file-change monitoring.
- [ ] Send security alerts to a monitored inbox, not an address nobody checks.
- [ ] Set up error logging and review it after launch.
- [ ] Keep a short incident plan: who to call, how to take the site offline and how to contact customers.
- [ ] Know how to revoke access quickly if a device or account is lost.

7. Privacy and legal basics

Security and privacy overlap. Do not collect data you cannot protect or explain.

- [ ] Publish a privacy policy that matches the data you collect.
- [ ] Add cookie consent if you use analytics, ads or non-essential cookies.
- [ ] Check that forms, newsletters and checkout flows link to the right policies.
- [ ] Remove test orders, test users and personal data before launch.
- [ ] Make sure contact and company details are accurate.

8. Launch-day checks

The final pass is about proving the site works in the real world, on real devices and with real data.

- [ ] Test every form and confirm submissions arrive.
- [ ] Test checkout, payment confirmation and the refund flow if you sell online.
- [ ] Check 404 pages, redirects and broken links.
- [ ] Remove noindex directives and confirm the site is indexable.
- [ ] Submit the sitemap in Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools.
- [ ] Test on a phone, a slow connection and a private browser window.
- [ ] Take a final backup and record the launch time.

> **Quick win:** do the account and backup sections first. They protect you even if you have to delay the launch by a day.